Former Teachers: Barriers, Incentives and Policy Lessons for Re-entry

Directorate for Education and Skills

WORKING DRAFT

Abstract

Résumé

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1. Introduction

Pendiente de escribir (al final de todo). Yo creo que aquí es clave resaltar los aprendizajes y que alguien que lea esto se quede con todo lo importante. Si alguien quiere detalles de research, que pueda pasar a la sección 2, y si quieren solo policy que pasen a 3.

Re-attracting former teachers has become one of the policy margins through which governments are trying to alleviate the current problem of teacher shortages. Although not sufficient to close the gap on its own, it can help reduce and fill vacancies in the short run, especially in the disadvantaged and rural schools where shortages tend to concentrate (UNESCO, 2024; Carver-Thomas and Darling-Hammond, 2019; Nguyen, Lam and Bruno, 2024). The magnitude of this policy margin depends on the baseline leaving and retirement rates, since in countries such as France, Greece, Ireland or Israel, whose low leaving rates are almost solely explained by retirement, its potential is scarce (OECD, 2025a). Beyond short-run relief to shortages, returners and retired teachers can bring benefits of their own, such as positive experience spillovers to colleagues, mentorship for beginning teachers and tutoring roles with experimental backing (Papay et al., 2020; DeCesare et al., 2017; Nickow, Oreopoulos and Quan, 2024).

2. Teacher leaving: rates, determinants and implications for re-entry

To design and evaluate the impact of policies that aim to bring former teachers back to the classroom it is fundamental to have a thorough understanding of the reasons why teachers leave. Moreover, it is crucial to identify the experiences and added value that former teachers can bring back to educational systems if they are successfully reintegrated. This debate is of central importance for governments that are making a wide range of efforts to retain and re-attract former teachers in response to the pressing challenges of an ageing teaching workforce, serious teacher shortages and the rising concerns over teachers' burnout and lack of mentorship (OECD, 2025a; UNESCO, 2024; Madigan and Kim, 2021; OECD, 2025b). This section therefore reviews what is known about why teachers leave, before the paper turns to the policies that have tried to bring them back.

First, we distinguish three main profiles of former teachers: (1) switchers, those who resign from teaching to take up other part-time or full-time employment, (2) leavers, those who withdraw from the labour market, and (3) retired teachers who have reached the end of their working lives. The determinants of leaving and the opportunity cost that each group faces when considering whether to re-enter vary significantly across these profiles. As the evidence reviewed in this section shows, switchers leave mainly over the conditions of the job and the standing of the profession, and pay weighs less in their decision than is often assumed; leavers leave for reasons that lie outside the school, mostly family and health, and respond above all to flexibility; and retired teachers leave when pension rules make it worthwhile, and are kept out of the classroom by those same rules once they have retired.

These institutional factors are nonetheless highly country-dependent, and a comprehensive description would require a paper of its own. Here we instead, we first describe the evolution and scope of the teacher leaving rate and posteriorly develop a general framework that classifies the most common motives for leaving and illustrates them with selected country examples. Each area of reasons closes with its implications for re-entry and with the profile it mainly concerns, and Box 1 at the end of the section brings them together.

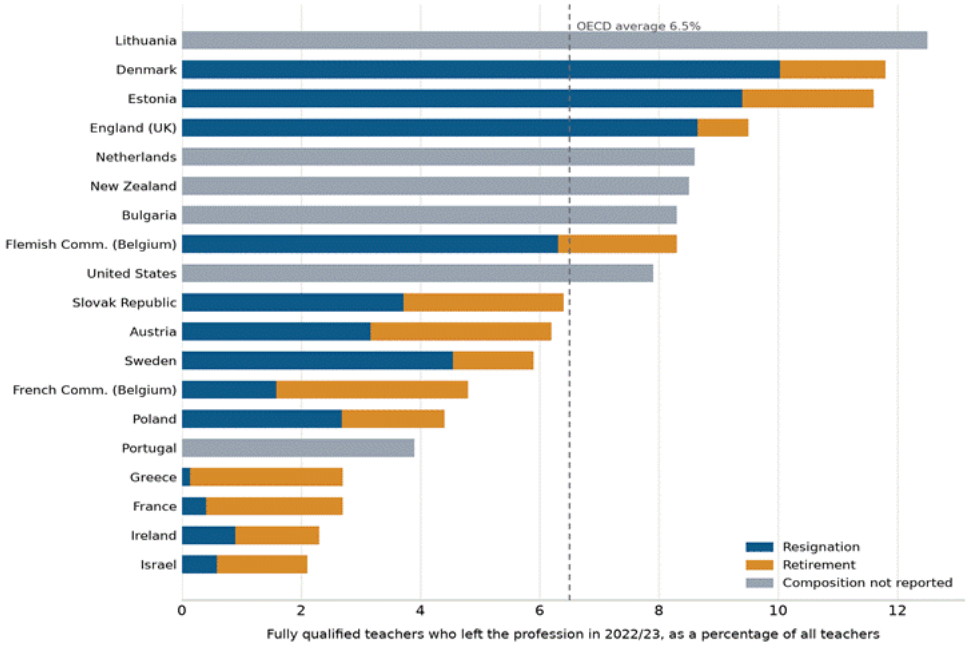
2.1 The teacher leaving rate and its evolution

The average teacher leaving rate across OECD countries was 6.5% in 2023, with considerable differences among the countries with available data (OECD, 2025a; see Figure 1). In countries with rates close to 2%, such as Israel, Ireland, France and Greece, the workforce renews itself through retirement

alone. In countries with higher rates, such as Lithuania, Denmark or Estonia, a larger share of departures corresponds to leavers and switchers. These systems must replace a substantial part of their stock every year, which raises questions about working conditions and retention.

The evolution of the leaving rate across time tends to be stable in most of the observed countries. The OECD average leaving rate moved from 6.9% in 2015 to 6.5% in 2023 and most systems present in both years moved by less than a percentage point (OECD, 2025a). Moreover, studies developed in countries with the longest available series confirm this stable trend. In USA, which holds one of the longest-running national series, the rate has oscillated between 5% and 8.5% across three and a half decades of survey waves, has sat near 8% for the last twenty years, and carries no lasting mark from the pandemic increase (NCES, 2024), and similar patterns hold in England, New Zealand, Sweden, Israel, Iceland, Norway and Flanders (Department for Education, 2024a; Education Counts, 2025; Adermon and Laun, 2018; CBS Israel, 2023; Björnsdóttir and Hansen, 2024; Statistics Norway, 2025; Vansteenkiste, 2025).

Figure 1. The teacher leaving rate and its composition, 2022/23



Note: Share of fully qualified teachers, full-time and part-time in public institutions, who left the profession during the reference year, from pre-primary to upper secondary education. The split into resignations and retirements is shown where reported; grey bars report the total rate only. The OECD average refers to the 19 countries and economies with available data. The reference year differs from 2022/23 for Denmark, France, New Zealand and England (2021/22). Data refer to primary and lower secondary education combined and exclude upper secondary education in Denmark, exclude upper secondary education in Israel and upper secondary vocational education in the Netherlands, and include non-fully qualified teachers in the Netherlands, New Zealand and the Flemish Community of Belgium. For the United States, leavers include teachers appointed to other positions in the education sector.

Source: OECD (2025a), Education at a Glance 2025, Table D8.4.

Regardless of how stable the leaving rate is over time, the teachers who make it up constitute a relevant policy margin. They are already trained, they have much to offer the education system, and they can bring back valuable experience gained in and outside the classroom, which also makes them a credible source for covering the local teacher shortages that most OECD

systems face today (OECD, 2026). The extent to which this margin can be mobilised depends, however, on the reasons that led these teachers to leave, both because those reasons are the levers through which systems can reduce departures and because they condition the design of any policy that seeks to bring former teachers back. The following section reviews what the literature has established on them.

2.2 Determinants of teachers leaving

The reasons why teachers leave the profession have been studied extensively, through surveys and interviews and, more recently, through administrative records of observed departures. Despite this abundance of evidence, ranking the reasons remains difficult. Studies differ in the populations they follow, in the outcomes they measure and in the way motives are grouped. Building on a comprehensive review of this literature and on the two most recent meta-analyses (Nguyen et al., 2020; Gundlach, Slemp and Hattie, 2024), this paper classifies the reasons into six reasons stated in Table 1. They are presented in this section starting with those that the evidence identifies as most important and ending with the least studied. Each area closes with its implications for policies that seek to re-attract former teachers, and Box 1 at the end of the section summarizes them.

Table 1. Reasons for leaving teaching, by area

Area	Reasons
Professional factors	Loss of professional purpose; limited autonomy over the work; professional standing; exposure to parental complaint and legal risk
Working conditions	Hours and total workload; pupil behaviour and classroom discipline; administrative and documentation demands; limited access to reduced hours; burnout and exhaustion
Organisational factors	School leadership; collegial support and team structure
Accountability and regulation	External inspection and its consequences; certification and licensing requirements
Financial factors	Salary relative to outside options; pension design and its timing incentives; contract insecurity
Personal and life-course factors	Family formation and care; childbirth; health and incapacity; relocation and a partner's circumstances; retirement and career stage

Source: Authors' elaboration on the literature reviewed in this section.

Working conditions

First, working conditions are the most frequently declared reason for intending to leave in international surveys. The area groups working hours and total workload, pupil behaviour and classroom discipline, class size,

administrative demands and the burnout that accumulates when these run together. Workload is understood here as the total time that teaching requires, in the school and in preparation and marking outside it, rather than the hours stipulated by contract. According to TALIS 2024, one in four teachers across the OECD intends to leave the profession within five years, and teachers who report high levels of stress are almost twice as likely to declare that intention. That stress comes mainly from administrative work and marking, from keeping up with changing government requirements and from maintaining classroom discipline (OECD, 2025b).

The surveys that ask leavers about the motives of their decision point particularly to workload, which emerges as the most cited motive among those related to working conditions. Leaver surveys done in the Netherlands, Sweden and Australia are consistent in this respect, although assigning different weights to what workload implies. In the Netherlands, workload, stress and burden were named ahead of every other category by 47% of recent leavers, who described intense working days, little rest within them and recurrent overtime, and 80% of them declared that they could have been retained, most often with less workload or a smaller class (Van Casteren et al., 2023). In Sweden, workload and parental expectations also came first, followed by administrative tasks and the lack of control over one's own work (Statistics Sweden, 2023), while in Australia the intensification of workload ranked second, behind dissatisfaction with school leadership, which is examined later in this section (Brandenburg et al., 2024).

However, teachers do not work longer hours than comparable professionals, when TALIS 2024 responses are compared with those of similarly qualified workers in the Survey of Adult Skills (PIAAC), teachers report fewer weekly hours in 13 of 26 covered countries and no clear difference in another 11 (OECD, 2025b). Hence, the workload that teachers declare goes beyond the number of hours stipulated by contract and mainly reflects the intensity of the work, the preparation and administrative tasks carried out outside school hours, and the burden they perceive in the classroom. A great example is observed in England, where TALIS responses were linked to administrative registers of the school workforce, so actual departures could be observed. Teachers in schools with worse discipline were twice as likely to leave the profession while the number of hours teachers worked did not predict their departure (Sims and Jerrim, 2020).

For policies that seek to re-attract former teachers, these findings carry two implications. The first is that the school and the teaching load offered to a returner are part of the policy, since the discipline climate of the school and the load are what drive departures (Sims and Jerrim, 2020; Van Casteren et al., 2023). Hence re-attraction is an opportunity to make a better match between the returning teacher and the school they arrive to. The second follows from the fact that shortages tend to concentrate in disadvantaged and rural schools, where the classroom climate is worst (Simon and Johnson, 2015; UNESCO, 2024): a former teacher sent back to one of these schools on the strength of an incentive alone would meet precisely the conditions that drive departures.

Organisational Factors

Closely linked to the daily pressures of teaching, organisational factors cover the quality of school leadership, the structuring of collaborative time and the degree of support among colleagues. Among these, dissatisfaction with school leadership is one of the most frequently cited predictors of teacher departure (Boyd et al., 2011; Ladd, 2011; Simon and Johnson, 2015). Nonetheless, establishing its causal effect is difficult, since teachers and principals self-select into schools and the association partly reflects that sorting rather than the effect of leadership itself.

The studies that overcome this problem, by following the same schools over time or by linking teachers' answers to administrative records of actual departures, confirm that leadership is central. Where teachers perceive their school to be well led, turnover is substantially lower, even after accounting for the other working conditions and for the characteristics of the students, and when the leadership of a school improves, its turnover falls (Boyd et al., 2011; Ladd, 2011; Kraft, Marinell and Shen-Wei Yee, 2016). The effect is largest precisely in disadvantaged schools, where an effective principal makes the greatest difference to whether teachers stay (Grissom, 2011).

Additionally, mentorship is another relevant organizational aspect, as it accelerates the pedagogical development of novice educators and mitigates the professional isolation common in early-career years. Across the OECD, however, only 26% of novice teachers had an assigned mentor in 2024, although four in five worked in schools that offer a mentoring programme (OECD, 2025b). Novice teachers who receive induction support are less likely to leave the profession (Nguyen et al., 2020), and precisely for this reason structured induction programmes have become one of the most common retention policies, with encouraging results where they have been evaluated. In England, for instance, the Early Career Framework, which entitles every new teacher to two years of mentoring, has increased retention within the original school (Walker et al., 2024). More broadly, collegial support and collaborative environments are consistently associated with lower intentions to leave (Johnson, Kraft and Papay, 2012; Simon and Johnson, 2015).

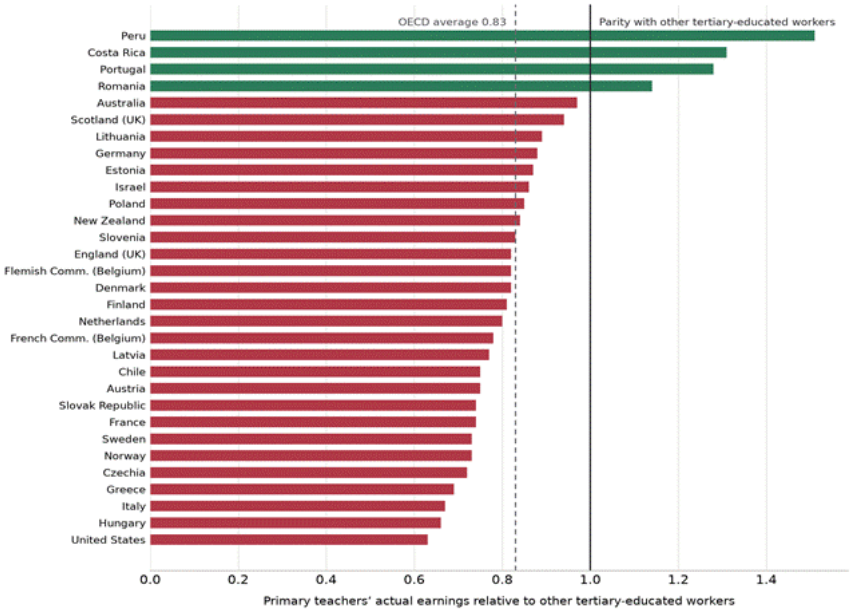
For policies that seek to re-attract former teachers, organisational factors matter in two ways. The first concerns the school to which returners are sent, since leadership and collegial support are decisive for all three profiles and a teacher who returns to a school with weak leadership encounters the same conditions that produced the first departure. For this reason, the return process itself could include early contact between the returning teacher and the leadership of the receiving school, so that the match is assessed before the placement is made. The second concerns the contribution that retired teachers can make, since in systems where fewer than one in three novice teachers has a mentor, experienced returners can fill that gap, and the peer interaction they bring has been shown to improve the instruction of their colleagues (Papay et al., 2020; DeCesare et al., 2017).

Financial factors

Thirdly, financial factors are the most extensively studied determinant of teacher retention. The area covers the salary relative to outside options, the design of pensions and the insecurity of contracts. From an economic perspective, retention depends on comparing teaching wages with the best alternative available outside. Because outside options vary by subject,

qualification and local labour market, uniform pay scales produce very different exit rates across disciplines and regions. For most teachers the comparison is unfavourable. Actual primary teacher salaries average 83% of the earnings of tertiary-educated workers across the OECD, with large differences across countries (see Figure 2). Only four systems pay at or above parity, led by Portugal at 128% of the benchmark, while the United States registers the lowest ratio at 63% (OECD, 2025d).

Figure 2. Teachers' salary compared to other tertiary-educated workers earnings



Note: Ratio of the average actual salary of full-time primary teachers in public institutions to the earnings of full-time tertiary-educated workers aged 25 to 64. Data refer to 2024 or the nearest available year.

Source: OECD (2025d), Education at a Glance 2025, Table D3.2.

The causal evidence on the effect of teacher payments confirms that financial incentives are effective to retain teachers, and payments cut departures by 9% to 23% in Norway, England and North Carolina (Falch, 2011; Sims and Benhenda, 2022; Clotfelter et al., 2008). This evidence rests on a small number of studies exploiting policy discontinuities, and lead to three main conclusions. Financial incentives are effective when the payment is large and teachers are aware of their eligibility (Falch, 2011; Clotfelter et al., 2008); their effect is confined to the teachers they target and is negligible for the rest (Springer, Swain and Rodriguez, 2016); and one-off bonuses produce larger short-run effects than permanent increases, which indicates that the retention gain does not persist beyond the payment period (Feng and Sass, 2018; See et al., 2020).

Moreover, pension rules also affect the decision to leave, since they set the retirement age and, along the teaching career, create incentives for retention depending on the pension system's rigidity. The retirement age generally falls between 62 and 67, averaging 64.7 for men and 63.9 for women across the OECD. It stands at 62 in Greece and Slovenia, at 67 in Australia, Denmark, Iceland, Israel, the Netherlands and Norway, and in between everywhere else (OECD, 2025f). In most schemes covering teachers, retiring before the age stipulated by law reduces the pension and retiring later marginally increases it, so retirement concentrates around that age (Baraton, Beffy and Fougère, 2011; Ni and Podgursky, 2016). In addition, in many public-service schemes

the pension is not freely compatible with a new salary, and retired teacher who returns sees the pension reduced or suspended once pension and salary together exceed a given threshold, which in practice excludes most retirees from teaching again unless a specific exception is made.

These rules matter because they shape the economic decisions that teachers take around retirement, and this phenomenon is closely related to the way pension entitlements accumulate. In defined-benefit schemes, where the pension is a share of the final salary that depends on years of service rather than on the contributions actually paid, most of the pension is earned in the final years before the full-pension age and little accrues after it, so one more year of work carries a substantial pension gain at 54 and almost nothing at 60 (Costrell and Podgursky, 2009). This is mostly the case across the civil-service teacher schemes of Europe and North America. Defined-contribution systems, where the pension depends on what has been contributed and on the return it has earned, as in Sweden or Australia, are instead close to actuarially neutral and spread retirements accordingly (OECD, 2025e). The available estimates of how much teachers value that deferred income present mixed results, with estimates running from about 20 cents per dollar of present value to near parity (Fitzpatrick, 2015; Ni, Podgursky and Wang, 2022), which suggests that the retention effect of pension rules depends as much on how well teachers understand them as on their actual generosity.

For policies that seek to re-attract former teachers, these findings carry two implications. The first concerns retired teachers, for whom pension rules are the main obstacle to returning, the more flexibility a system offers them to teach again without losing their pension, and with the possibility of earning an additional income, the more effective it will be in re-attracting them, which is the logic behind several of the policies examined in Section 3. The second concerns switchers, for whom, as expected, better salaries increase the likelihood of returning. The causal evidence reviewed above nonetheless warns that pay alone retains teachers only while it is paid, so that keeping returners in the profession depends on the working and organisational conditions discussed in the previous areas rather than on the financial incentive that brought them back.

Professional factors

Fourth, professional factors group the motives related to the purpose, autonomy and standing of teaching. This area covers teachers who leave because they no longer find meaning in their work, who feel they have lost control over how to exercise it, or who perceive a deterioration in the standing of the profession, often linked to exposure to parental complaints and legal action.

The available evidence consistently shows that these motives weigh on the decision to leave, both among teachers who intend to leave and among those who have already done so. In Finland a longitudinal survey that followed teachers over five years found that a lack of professional commitment was named persistently, above workload and interpersonal difficulties among teachers declaring an intention to leave the profession (Räsänen et al., 2020). In England teachers who intend to leave give more weight to the feeling that their views are not considered by policymakers than to wages (Department for Education, 2024b). Among actual leavers, the pattern remains consistent. In

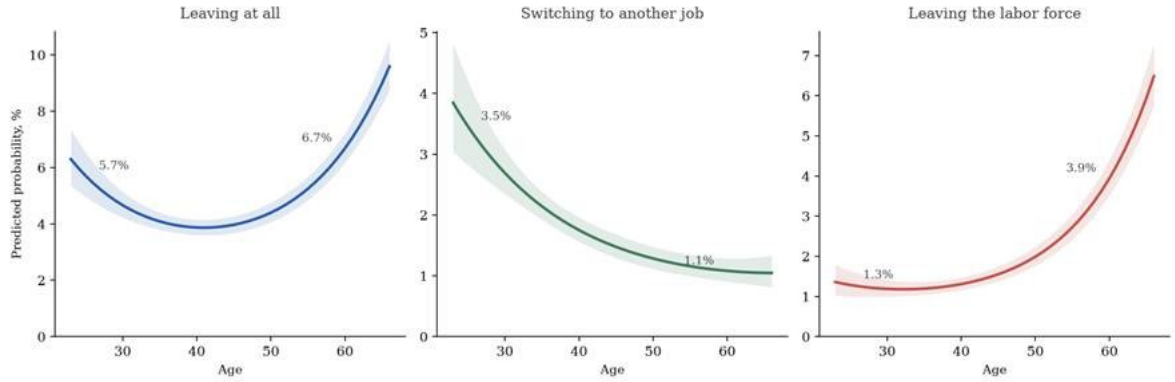
the United States, most switchers rate their new job above teaching in autonomy, influence and professional prestige, although not always in salary (NCES, 2014), and in the leaver surveys of the Netherlands and Sweden the lack of professional challenge and the limited control over one's own work rank among the leading motives, behind working conditions only (Van Casteren et al., 2023; Statistics Sweden, 2023).

Moreover, the apparent decline in the perceived standing of the profession is not only a problem for those who decide to leave. Across the OECD, only 26% of teachers feel that their profession is valued in society, and those who do are over 10% less likely to intend to leave within five years (OECD, 2020; OECD, 2025b). Taken together, the evidence points to recognition and professional purpose as decisive in the leaving decision, consistent with teaching remaining one of the most vocational career choices. This matters for policies that seek to bring former teachers back, and particularly switchers, who are the ones who found elsewhere the autonomy and standing they missed, since it highlights the importance of recognising their previous service, of offering roles that make use of their experience and of initiatives that increase their participation in decisions about their own work.

Personal and life-course factors

Fifth, personal and life-course factors drive a substantial share of departures and, unlike the preceding areas, originate entirely outside the school, which makes them the least predictable from an institutional perspective and the least responsive to standard administrative aspects. Along the teaching career, the leaving rate exhibits a pronounced U-shape, concentrated among novice teachers during early-career sorting and among late-career teachers approaching retirement, with a stable middle phase (Nguyen et al., 2020). Figure 3 shows this profile for the United States and separates the two exit routes behind it.

Figure 3. The age profile of leaving teaching in the United States, by exit route



Note: Predicted probabilities of leaving teaching within twelve months, by age, from probit models estimated on Current Population Survey data (March supplements) for college-graduate teachers observed between 2015 and 2024. Each panel comes from a separate model, with age entered as a quadratic, year effects, and the other covariates held at their sample means. Left: leaving teaching by any route; centre: moving to another occupation; right: leaving the labour force. Exits to unemployment are the residual route and are not shown, so the two right panels do not sum exactly to the left one. Shaded bands are 95% confidence intervals. Authors' calculations.

The early peak is driven by switchers, since the probability of moving to another occupation is highest among the youngest teachers and declines steadily with age, as novice teachers leave for further study, family formation or alternative employment while the quality of their match with the profession

is still being revealed (Guarino, Santibañez and Daley, 2006). The late peak is driven by leavers, whose probability of withdrawing from the labour force rises sharply after the age of 55 in response to the retirement incentives just examined (Costrell and Podgursky, 2009).

The teaching workforce is predominantly female, at around seven in ten lower secondary teachers across the OECD (OECD, 2025b). The events of family life weigh on it with particular force, and the birth of a child is the best documented of these motives. In England, where the workforce census follows teachers after maternity leave, between 17% and 20% of those who return leave the profession within a year, doubling the rate of comparable teachers, and women aged 30 to 39 form the largest group among leavers (Department for Education, 2023). Similarly in the United States and Sweden the same event has long driven female exits (Stinebrickner, 2002).

However, childbirth is only the most visible of a broader set of family and health circumstances that lead teachers to withdraw from the labour market, and the leaver surveys that record them show that these circumstances weigh as much as childbirth itself. Personal life reasons, covering health, childcare and the care of relatives, form the most important non-retirement motive among American voluntary leavers, at 15% (NCES, 2024), and the difficulty of combining work and family is named by 15% of Swedish leavers (Statistics Sweden, 2023).

This matters for policies that seek to bring former teachers back, since those who left over a birth or a family obligation did not leave over the conditions of the school, and the constraint behind the exit tends to ease with time. The evidence nonetheless suggests that their return does not follows on its own when the family circumstances that generated the leaving decision have ceased, only a minority of those who leave come back (Grissom and Reininger, 2012; Moyer, 2022). Flexibility therefore emerges as the central lever for this profile. Part-time and phased returns, predictable timetables and placements compatible with care responsibilities improve re-entry in general and, above all, facilitate the return of those who leave temporarily.

Accountability and regulation

Finally, accountability and regulation group the motives related to external teacher evaluation and to statutory licensing rules. In general, the evaluation of teachers can be divided into internal evaluations, carried out by the school's own leadership, and external evaluation, carried out by a public body, usually a national or regional inspection regulated by education ministries or equivalent authorities. The internal revisions are common, since 64% of teachers across the OECD work in schools where the principal evaluates every teacher at least once a year and 51% in schools where other members of the management team do so, most often on the basis of classroom observation (OECD, 2020).

Beyond evaluation, maintaining a valid teaching license requires meeting specific regulatory obligations that vary by country, typically taking the form of mandatory periodic training or documented evidence of continued classroom practice. The obligation consists either of completing training, which ranges from 8 hours a year in Luxembourg to 35 in Scotland and from three to five days in Belgium, Finland, Cyprus, Lithuania and Slovenia (European Commission/EACEA/Eurydice, 2021), or of a minimum amount of

teaching, such as 20 days a year in Australia or two years of classroom practice in New Zealand (Victorian Institute of Teaching, 2025; Teaching Council of Aotearoa New Zealand, 2016).

However, what matters for leavers is the additional time and work these obligations imply, since nearly half report that evaluation in their school is carried out merely to fulfil administrative requirements, without producing feedback they can use, and 54% that their mandatory training competes with their working schedule (OECD, 2020). The importance of accountability and regulation motives is nonetheless minor compared to other determinants of leaving, since even if test-based accountability does elevate stress and turnover intentions (Ryan et al., 2017), it ranks below affective commitment, burnout and job satisfaction (Gundlach, Slemp and Hattie, 2024).

For policies aiming to re-attract former teachers, this suggests that the cost of re-certification deserves particular attention. Licensing requirements rarely drive fully qualified teachers out of the profession, although teachers who entered without full certification do leave at higher rates (Redding and Smith, 2016), but they become a real barrier at the moment of return, since a lapsed licence must be renewed and the cost and the isolation that teachers face in navigating the process deter re-entry and reduce retention once back. This concerns all three profiles and argues for keeping such burdens as low as regulatory purposes allow.

General overview

Not all these motives have been studied with the same intensity, and their relative importance cannot be compared perfectly across studies. The best basis for doing so comes from the two meta-analyses used throughout this section, which together pool several hundred studies of teacher turnover and estimate the weight of each antecedent for intentions as well as for observed departures (Nguyen et al., 2020; Gundlach, Slemp and Hattie, 2024). Both point to working conditions and the organisational features of the school as the most consistent determinants of leaving, above financial incentives, accountability and personal characteristics. Teachers exposed to high workload, stress and weak organisational support are substantially more likely to leave, while pay and regulation, although relevant, have smaller effects. This does not make personal motives secondary for every teacher. It means that the conditions under which teaching takes place are the main institutional margin through which systems can influence retention.

This distinction matters for policies that aim to re-attract former teachers. Bringing a teacher back without changing the conditions under which they left risks reproducing the same decision later on. Re-entry policies should therefore be understood not only as a way to reduce the cost of returning, but as an opportunity to improve the match between teachers and schools, a manageable load, supportive leadership and colleagues, adequate classroom conditions and, where the exit was personal, the flexibility to combine teaching with family responsibilities. The relevant question is not simply how to make former teachers return, but whether the system can offer them a different set of conditions once they do.

Box 1. What the reasons for leaving teach us about re-attracting former teachers

Each reason for leaving points to a profile of former teachers and to a lever for bringing them back.

Working conditions. *Switchers and leavers.* What drives departures is the climate of the classroom more than the hours worked. Because shortages concentrate in the schools where that climate is worst, a returner placed there on the strength of an incentive alone is likely to leave again. The school a returner is placed in and the teaching load they are offered are part of the policy.

Organisational factors. *All profiles.* Supportive leadership and collegial support are the most consistent predictors of staying, so returners should go to schools where they exist. Retired teachers can also supply what is missing: only one in four novice teachers has a mentor, and mentoring is the organisational lever with the clearest effect on early-career retention.

Financial factors. *Switchers and retired teachers.* Pay brings teachers back and keeps them only for as long as it is paid. For retired teachers the binding constraint is not the salary but the pension rules that penalise working after retirement; removing those penalties costs little and acts directly on the largest reserve of experienced teachers.

Professional factors. *Mainly switchers.* Those who leave for another job rate it above teaching in autonomy, influence and standing, more than in pay. Bringing them back means recognising their previous service, offering roles that use their experience and giving them a say in decisions about their own work.

Personal and life-course factors. *Mainly leavers.* Those who left over a birth, care or health did not leave over the school, and the constraint often eases with time. Yet they no longer return on their own: only about one in five does. They respond to flexibility, through part-time and phased returns, predictable timetables and placements compatible with care, and to being asked.

Accountability and regulation. *Minor as a reason for leaving, decisive for re-entry.* Licensing and training obligations rarely drive qualified teachers out, but a lapsed licence must be renewed, and the cost and complexity of doing so deter those considering a return. Re-certification should be as light as its purpose allows.

Overall. Working conditions and the organisation of the school outweigh pay, regulation and personal characteristics as reasons for leaving. The conditions a former teacher returns to therefore matter as much as the incentive that brings them back, and a policy driven only by shortages, which places returners in the hardest schools, risks reproducing the first departure. Seen in this light, re-entry policies are also an opportunity to improve the match between teachers and schools, through the workload, the leadership, the collegial environment, the classroom conditions and the flexibility that returners are offered.

3. The policies

Education systems have used five instruments to bring former teachers back into schools: financial incentives, information and nudges, support and training, flexible positions and flexible re-certification. This section reviews 30 policies from 18 countries. Most respond to teacher shortages, most target retired teachers and most are short-term measures adopted to fill local vacancies quickly. Take-up is small relative to the size of the teaching workforce, and few policies have been evaluated.

The evidence that does exist points to two conclusions. First, single instruments achieve little on their own. The policies that report the best results combine several instruments and pay attention to the conditions that returners find in schools. Second, former teachers appear most valuable when their role draws on their experience, as mentors, tutors or flexible staff. The strongest experimental evidence in this review concerns those roles.

Section 3.1 describes the policies as a whole. Sections 3.2 to 3.6 then examine each instrument in turn, with boxes on selected country cases. Section 3.7 draws lessons for the design of re-entry policies.

3.1 Main features of the policies

The 30 policies reviewed come from Australia, Austria, the Bahamas, Canada, China, France, Germany, Ireland, Japan, the Netherlands, New Zealand, Portugal, Singapore, Spain, Sweden, Switzerland, the United Kingdom and the United States (Table 2). They were compiled from legal texts, official documents, parliamentary records and institutional evaluations. Reputable press reports were used only where no official source exists. Officials in Lower Saxony (Germany), Quebec (Canada) and New Zealand provided further information. All policies were checked against their primary sources in October 2026. Each policy is classified under its main instrument, although many combine several.

Table 2. Policies to re-attract former teachers, by main instrument and target group

Instrument	Policies reviewed (target group)
Financial incentives	Canada: Ontario (R), Quebec (R); France (R); Germany: Lower Saxony, earnings ceiling (R); Ireland (R); Netherlands (S/L); Portugal (R); United States: Georgia (R), Louisiana (R), Michigan (R), New Mexico (R), North Carolina (R)
Information and nudges	Australia: New South Wales (All); Austria (R); Germany: Lower Saxony, letter (R); Japan: Miyazaki (S/L); United Kingdom: England, advisers (S/L)
Support and training	Australia: Victoria (All); Sweden (S/L); Switzerland: Zurich (S/L); United Kingdom: England, pilot programme (S/L)
Flexible positions	Bahamas (All); China (R); Singapore (All); Spain: Zaragoza (R); United States: AARP Foundation Experience Corps (R), Colorado (R), four urban districts (R)
Flexible re-certification	New Zealand (S/L); United States: Virginia (R)

Note: R: retired teachers; S/L: switchers and leavers; All: switchers, leavers and retired teachers. Each policy is listed under its main instrument. Secondary instruments are discussed in the text. AARP Foundation Experience Corps recruits adults aged 50 and over, not only former teachers.

Source: Legal texts, official documents, parliamentary records and evaluations cited in Section 3, verified in October 2026.

Most policies respond to teacher shortages

The large majority of the policies were adopted to fill vacancies. Many target shortages that are local or concentrated in particular subjects. Georgia limited its return-to-work law to the subjects of highest need in each region, and Louisiana and Virginia to posts declared critical shortages. Portugal allowed retired teachers to be hired only for shortage subjects or under-staffed schools. Lower Saxony's letter to teachers about to retire named science, technology, engineering and mathematics (STEM), music, art and certain districts as its priorities. China sends retired teachers to rural schools in the poorest counties.

The COVID-19 pandemic created or extended a large group of these policies. Absences among serving teachers multiplied the need for substitutes. Quebec introduced its incentives for retired teachers in autumn 2020, by decree under the health emergency. Ontario raised the number of days that retirees may work without losing their pension from 50 to 95 in each school year from 2020/21 to 2022/23. Ireland waived the reduction of pensions for retired substitutes in 2021. In December 2021, England called on recently retired teachers and career changers to cover absences during the Omicron wave (Department for Education, 2021).

A smaller group of policies pursues a different aim: to use the experience of former teachers in roles that serving teachers rarely have time for. China asks retired principals and senior teachers to coach young teachers in rural schools. In the United States, retired teachers have mentored new teachers in Aurora, Colorado, and tutored pupils who were falling behind in mathematics and reading. At the University of Zaragoza (Spain), retired teachers mentored

student teachers. Singapore's adjunct teaching programme aims to keep teachers who resign in contact with schools on flexible terms.

Financial incentives are the most common instrument

Financial incentives are the main instrument of 12 of the 30 policies. Most change the rules on combining a pension with a salary, as in Ireland, Lower Saxony and Michigan. Seven policies offer flexible positions, as in China and Singapore. Five rely on information and nudges, as in Lower Saxony and New South Wales (Australia). Four provide support and training, as in England and Victoria (Australia). Two make re-certification more flexible: New Zealand and Virginia.

The policies target the three profiles of former teachers unevenly. Of the 30 policies, 19 target retired teachers only, 7 target switchers and leavers, and 4 are open to all three profiles. Retired teachers are easy to identify and fully qualified, and many retire before they wish to stop working altogether. The main obstacle to their return is also a rule that governments control directly: the reduction or suspension of the pension when a retiree takes paid work in the public sector (Section 2). Changing that rule is cheap and quick, which explains why it is the most common policy in the review. Switchers and leavers, who make up most former teachers below retirement age, are the target of fewer and smaller programmes.

Most policies are short-term remedies

Many policies were enacted with an end date and then renewed for one period at a time. Ireland's waiver of pension reduction was introduced in 2021 and has been extended twice, most recently to the end of 2027. Michigan's rules expire in October 2028 and Virginia's in July 2028. Georgia's law expired in June 2026 and was replaced by a new law that expires in 2030. Quebec renegotiates its incentives with the teacher unions every school year. Others were reversed. Ontario's teachers' federation refused to extend the higher limit on working days in 2024. Portugal repealed its programme for hiring retired teachers in September 2026, two years after creating it, because it had ceased to be justified (Government of Portugal, 2026). This pattern reflects the purpose of most policies, which is to fill vacancies quickly. Few treat former teachers as a permanent source of teacher supply.

Take-up is small, but returners matter for teacher supply

Where take-up is reported, it is small relative to the teaching workforce. In Germany, a 2023 survey of the federal states counted more than 5 000 retired teachers who had stayed on or returned, under 1% of about 800 000 teachers (Kuhn, 2023). In Georgia, about 350 retirees a year returned under the state's return-to-work law, also under 1% of teachers (Georgia Department of Audits and Accounts, 2025). Portugal validated 55 retired teachers for a quota of 200 places (Observador, 2024). In Vienna, 3 of nearly 300 retired teachers contacted by the education directorate returned to school (ORF Wien, 2023).

Returners nonetheless form a large share of new entrants in some systems. In England, returners accounted for 17 740 full-time equivalent qualified teachers entering state schools in 2025/26. This is 43.3% of all qualified entrants, up from 39.6% in 2023/24, and more than the 16 300 newly qualified teachers who started that year (Department for Education, 2026a). In Sweden, about 3% of the teaching workforce returned in 2019 (Skolverket, 2020). Most

of these returners came back without any dedicated programme. The size of this margin therefore depends on the conditions of the profession at least as much as on any single instrument.

Evidence on effectiveness is scarce

Only a handful of the 30 policies have been evaluated, and only three evaluations are randomised trials (Table 3). All three concern flexible positions: retired teachers as mentors of new teachers and as tutors of young pupils. Three official reviews of re-entry programmes, in England, the Netherlands and Sweden, found low conversion of interest into returns, substantial deadweight or a failure to reach the target group. Studies of rules on combining pension and salary in Georgia, North Carolina and Virginia describe who returned and where, but cannot identify the effect of the rules on vacancies or pupil learning.

The retention of returners once back in school is almost never measured. Georgia, where 43% of the retirees hired in 2023 were still teaching two years later, is an exception. In most systems the data do not allow returners to be linked to the policy that brought them back. Lower Saxony, for example, has no unique teacher identifier with which to follow individual careers.

Table 3. Evaluations of policies to re-attract former teachers

Policy	Assessment	Main findings
Georgia (United States), return to work in high-need subjects	State audit of administrative data, 2023-2025	About 350 returners a year, under 1% of teachers; 64% returned to their former system; 43% of the 2023 cohort still teaching two years later
North Carolina (United States), full return with pension, 1999-2009	Descriptive study of administrative data	About 3 500 returners; 54% returned to their own school; returners more often employed in the poorest schools; effects on vacancies not identified
Virginia (United States), return to critical-shortage posts	Retirement system report	Shorter break in service raised July-October returns from 18 to 150
Netherlands, grant to schools that re-hire former teachers	Ministry evaluation based on school boards' reports	274 returners funded; most would have been hired anyway; not extended
Austria, retired teachers recruited back	Qualitative study, 14 interviews	None of the returners interviewed would repeat their return
England (United Kingdom), Return to Teaching pilot	Independent evaluation with comparison group	5 729 registrations, 354 supported, 27 in permanent posts; GBP 37 400 per additional returner
Sweden, online course for returning teachers	Agency report with participant survey	1 018 registered, 38 completed the course; did not reach its target group
Colorado (United States), retired teachers mentor new teachers	Randomised trial, 77 teachers	Mathematics +0.064 after year 1, not significant after year 2; no effect on reading or retention
Four urban districts (United States), mathematics tutoring	Randomised trial, 994 pupils	Mathematics +0.34
AARP Foundation Experience Corps (United States), reading tutoring	Randomised trial, 23 schools	Reading comprehension +0.13 to +0.17 for pupils with 35 sessions or more

Note: Effect sizes are standardised mean differences. Studies listed in the order of Sections 3.2 to 3.5.

Source: Georgia Department of Audits and Accounts (2025); Jarrold-Grapes and Mahler (2024); Virginia Retirement System (2023); Tweede Kamer (2020); Resch (2025); Buchanan et al. (2018); Skolverket (2020); DeCesare et al. (2017); Gersten et al. (2015); Morrow-Howell et al. (2009).

3.2 Financial incentives

Financial incentives are the most widely used instrument, and they mostly target retired teachers. They take two forms. The first, and by far the most

common, is a change in the rules on combining a pension with a salary, so that retired teachers can return without losing all or part of their pension. The second consists of direct payments, either to the returning teacher or to the school that hires them. As Section 2 showed, pay brings teachers back only for as long as it is paid, while pension rules often decide whether a retired teacher can return at all.

Rules on combining pension and salary

In most public-service pension plans, a retiree who takes paid work in the public sector has the pension reduced or suspended in two situations: when pension and salary together pass a threshold, or when the retiree works more than a set number of days. The policies reviewed relax these rules in three ways. Some allow a number of working days a year without any reduction. Some raise or remove the earnings ceiling. Others allow a full return, with full pension and full salary, but only in posts that are hard to fill.

Ireland and Ontario (Canada) follow the first approach. In Ireland, a public-service pension is reduced when the retiree's new earnings and pension together exceed the pay the retiree received on retiring, uprated over time. Since 2021, the Department of Education has waived this reduction for the first 50 days that a retired teacher works in a calendar year. Any day worked counts as a full day, whatever the hours. The waiver applies only where the need cannot practicably be met by a teacher who is not retired, and it is lost if the retiree takes a post that extends beyond 50 days. The current circular covers 2026 and 2027 (Department of Education, 2026).

In Ontario, retired teachers may work for up to 50 days in a school year and keep their full pension. Beyond that limit, the pension is suspended from the end of the month and resumes when the retiree stops working or at the start of the next school year. The provincial government and the Ontario Teachers' Federation, which sponsor the pension plan together, raised the limit to 95 days in each school year from 2020/21 to 2022/23. The higher limit applied only to positions that could not be filled by other qualified teachers, and school boards reported each month on how they used it (Ontario Teachers' Federation, 2020). In March 2024, the federation declined the Ministry of Education's request to extend it again (Ontario Teachers' Federation, 2024).

Lower Saxony (Germany), France, Michigan and New Mexico follow the second approach. Lower Saxony raised the earnings ceiling for retired civil-service teachers from 125% to 150% of their pensionable pay in October 2022. In October 2024 it abolished the ceiling for those who have reached the statutory retirement age (Box 5). In France, a retired teacher who has claimed all pensions and receives a full-rate pension can combine pension and salary without limit. For other retirees, the pension is reduced when earnings pass a threshold (Assemblée nationale, 2026). Since 2023, retirees who combine a full-rate pension with work also accrue new pension rights.

Michigan's Public Act 147 of 2023 shortened the waiting period after retirement from nine to six months. After six months, a retiree may return to any school post without an earnings limit or any effect on the pension. During the waiting period, earnings are capped at USD 15 100 a year. The law expires in October 2028 (Michigan Office of Retirement Services, 2023). New Mexico's Educational Retirees Returning to Work Act of 2022 allows retirees to return 90 days after retiring, with no limit on earnings, once the Educational

Retirement Board has approved the return. Returners and employers pay contributions that earn no further pension rights. The maximum period of return was 36 months and was extended to 60 months in 2025 (New Mexico Educational Retirement Board, 2025). When the law was announced, about 48 000 retired educators were eligible (Office of the Governor of New Mexico, 2022).

The third approach ties the full return to shortage posts. Georgia's House Bill 385 allowed teachers retired with 30 years of service to return full-time in the subjects of highest need in their region (Box 3). Louisiana's Act 344 of 2026 requires a break of 12 months after retirement and limits most returners' earnings to 50% of their final average pay, up from 25%. Returners may earn a full salary without any reduction of the pension in posts certified as critical shortages. To certify a shortage, the employer must advertise the post and receive fewer than three qualified applications from candidates who are not retired (Teachers' Retirement System of Louisiana, 2026).

Virginia has allowed retirees to return to critical-shortage posts while keeping their pension since 2001. Between 2008 and 2022, retirees filled 699 such posts. In July 2023, the state shortened the required break in service from 12 to 6 months, added specialist support posts and extended the rule to July 2028. Retirees returning between July and October rose from 18 in 2022 to 150 in 2023, an increase that the state's retirement system attributes to the shorter break (Virginia Retirement System, 2023).

North Carolina offers the longest experience with this approach. Between 1999 and 2009, retired teachers could return full-time and draw salary and pension together, which could raise their income by as much as half. In 1999 the rule applied only to low-performing schools, but this restriction was lifted in 2000. About 3 500 teachers returned, and 52% of schools hired at least one. More than half of returners (54%) went back to their own school. Returners were more often found in the poorest schools: 30% worked in the poorest quartile of schools, against 21% in the least poor quartile (Jarrold-Grapes and Mahler, 2024).

Portugal took the most restrictive route. Decree-Law 51/2024 allowed schools to offer fixed-term contracts to teachers who had retired five years ago or less. The posts had to be in shortage subjects or in under-staffed schools, within an annual national quota. Returners kept their pension and received an additional payment linked to the first step of the salary scale, in proportion to their weekly hours (Government of Portugal, 2024). In the first round, 79 retirees expressed interest and 55 were validated for 200 places (Observador, 2024). The programme was repealed with effect from 1 September 2026 (Government of Portugal, 2026).

These rules differ in who pays. Under Georgia's law, the employer paid both the employer and the employee contributions to the pension fund, and the returner earned no further service credit. In New Mexico, Louisiana and, since 2023, Virginia, contributions are paid on the returner's salary without adding to the pension. Such designs limit the cost of the policy to the pension system and avoid rewarding early retirement.

Box 2. Quebec (Canada): Paying retired teachers on their salary step

Quebec's incentives for retired teachers began in autumn 2020, under the COVID-19 health emergency. Until then, a retired teacher who covered an absence received the flat daily rate for supply teaching. The teacher reached the salary scale only after 20 consecutive days in the same replacement. A government decree of September 2020 modified the collective agreements so that teachers retired in the previous five years were paid from the first day at the step of the salary scale that matched their experience and qualifications. They kept their full pension and paid no further contributions. For a retiree at the top of the scale, the daily pay rose from a usual maximum of about CAD 212 to about CAD 412 (Gouvernement du Québec, 2022). The government estimated the cost at about CAD 4 545 per retiree for each 20-day replacement (Conseil exécutif du Québec, 2020).

From 1 October 2021, a temporary premium of 7.89% was added. The emergency measures ended with the 2021/22 school year. Since 2022/23, the incentives have been renewed each year through letters of agreement signed outside the collective agreements with each teacher union federation. The premiums have changed with each agreement: 7.89% until 2023/24; 7.5% on supply work and 12.5% on contracts of three months or more in 2024/25; and 12.5% on contracts of one month or more from 2025/26. The five-year limit was lifted, and the 2024/25 agreement covers any retired teacher who is legally qualified to teach. Employers must first offer the work to qualified staff they already employ.

The Ministry of Education funds the measure after the fact, from the use of retired staff that school service centres report each year. The envelope for 2026/27 is being adjusted downwards, as fewer retirees are used and the 7.5% premium has been withdrawn (Ministère de l'Éducation du Québec, 2026). About 700 retirees returned in 2020/21, more than 2 900 in 2022/23 and more than 5 000 in 2024/25 (Desrosiers, 2023; Le Devoir, 2025). With the premium, a retiree at the top of the scale could earn up to CAD 460 a day in 2023 (Desrosiers, 2023). In June 2023 and August 2025, the minister also wrote to retired teachers to ask them to return. The measure has not been evaluated.

Lessons. Paying returners on their own salary step removes the main financial penalty of supply work for experienced teachers. The cost is moderate, because the payment is made only for days actually worked. Annual renegotiation keeps the measure responsive to shortages, but it also leaves retirees and school service centres uncertain about the terms from one year to the next.

Source: Conseil exécutif du Québec (2020); Gouvernement du Québec (2022); Desrosiers (2023); Le Devoir (2025); Ministère de l'Éducation du Québec (2026).

Box 3. Georgia (United States): What an audit shows about returning retirees

From July 2022 to June 2026, Georgia's House Bill 385 allowed teachers who had retired with at least 30 years of service, and had been retired for at least a year, to return to a full-time classroom post. The post had to be in one of the subjects of highest need in their region, as set by the regional education service agency. Returners drew a full salary on top of the full pension. The employer paid both the employer and the employee contributions to the pension fund, and the returner earned no further service credit.

A state audit published in 2025 is one of the few assessments of such a rule. Between 2023 and 2025, 635 retirees returned under the law, rising from 241 to 428 a year. That is an average of about 350 a year, under 1% of the state's teachers. Just over half of school systems (55%) used the law, and 64% of returners went back to the system they had retired from. In 56% of the systems that used it, the post had first been offered to a candidate who was not retired. Of the 2023 cohort, 43% were still teaching two years later. Among the systems that did not use the law, 45 of 72 said they would have liked to, but could find no eligible retiree.

The law expired in June 2026. Senate Bill 150 replaced it until June 2030. Under the new law, at least half of the returner's timetable must be in a qualifying subject, such as mathematics, science, special education or career and technical education. Each school system now defines its own areas of highest need from a five-year average of vacancies.

Lessons. Strict eligibility keeps the cost of the rule low but also its reach. The retirees who qualify are few and are concentrated where they used to work. Defining need locally, as the new law does, may bring the rule closer to the vacancies it is meant to fill.

Source: Georgia Department of Audits and Accounts (2025); Teachers Retirement System of Georgia (2026).

Direct payments

Direct payments to returners are less common. Quebec's measure is the clearest example (Box 2). Several other policies include a payment as a secondary instrument. Victoria pays former teachers an honorarium during a supported placement of up to 40 days (Box 9). China pays the retired teachers it posts to rural schools an allowance of CNY 20 000 a year (Box 11). New Zealand has paid the registration fees of returning teachers since October 2024, a measure extended to all teachers from July 2025 (Box 13). Portugal's additional payment for retired teachers ended with the repeal of its programme. A separate supplement of EUR 750 a month remains for teachers who could retire but keep teaching in shortage regions, which is a retention measure (Government of Portugal, 2026).

The Netherlands paid the school instead (Box 4). The Dutch experience illustrates a general risk of payments to employers: they may reward hiring decisions that would have been taken anyway.

Box 4. The Netherlands: A grant to schools that re-hired former teachers

From November 2017, school boards in primary education could claim a flat EUR 2 500 for each qualified teacher they hired after a break of at least 12 months from primary teaching. The contract had to last at least six months. The grant also covered qualified teachers who had never taught. It was paid to the school board to cover coaching and refresher training in the returner's first months back, and was not meant as a salary supplement. The first budget, of EUR 1.25 million, allowed for up to 500 returners by the end of 2018. Further rounds were funded in 2019 and 2020, and applications closed in October 2020 (Ministerie van OCW, 2017; 2019).

The grant was used for 274 returners between October 2017 and June 2020. School boards told the ministry that most of these teachers would have been hired and supported without it. The ministry concluded that the grant had contributed only to a limited extent, and did not extend it (Tweede Kamer, 2020).

The pool of potential returners is large. In 2024, 34 000 qualified primary teachers and 64 000 secondary and vocational teachers were not working in education. About 2 400 qualified teachers return to primary education each year, half as many as ten years earlier (DUO, 2026). However, most members of this pool already work in other parts of the public sector, such as health care (de Vries, van Klaveren and Stolp, 2025).

Lessons. A small flat grant to employers did not change hiring decisions. Schools hired the returners they needed and absorbed the cost of supporting them. A payment large enough to change behaviour, or one tied to hard-to-fill posts, would be needed to avoid deadweight.

Source: Ministerie van OCW (2017; 2019); Tweede Kamer (2020); DUO (2026); de Vries, van Klaveren and Stolp (2025).

What the evidence shows

Three findings emerge from the evidence on financial incentives. First, the conditions attached to a rule matter as much as the incentive. When Virginia shortened the required break in service, returns in the first months of the school year rose more than eightfold. In Portugal, the limits on the date of retirement, subjects and places left most of the quota unfilled. In Georgia, 45 school systems wanted to use the rule but could find no retiree who met its conditions.

Second, rules that allow a full return tend to channel retirees towards the schools that most need them. In North Carolina and Georgia, returners were concentrated in high-need subjects and, in North Carolina, in the poorest schools. Most returners also went back to the system or school where they had worked. This suggests that these rules mainly help schools keep their own experienced staff for longer.

Third, these rules raise concerns that are worth anticipating. Ontario's teachers' federation refused to extend the higher limit on working days in 2024. It argued that more than 30 000 certified teachers were not employed by school boards and that a generous rule could encourage early retirement (Ontario Teachers' Federation, 2024). Returners themselves may find the experience less rewarding than expected. In Austria, retired teachers who

return are hired on new contracts, and none of the 14 returners interviewed in a 2025 study said they would repeat the experience (Resch, 2025).

3.3 Information and nudges

A second group of policies informs former teachers of the options available to them, or prompts them to consider returning. These policies use letters, calls, advisers and information sessions. They are cheap, and they respond to a barrier that Section 2 identified: many former teachers are open to returning but are not asked, do not know how to return, or expect the process to be burdensome. Lower Saxony's minister wrote to teachers about to retire that many would consider teaching a few hours a week but were put off by the paperwork (Niedersächsisches Kultusministerium, 2023).

Timing and the messenger matter

Austria offers a cautionary case. In December 2022, the education directorate of Vienna contacted nearly 300 retired teachers, and three returned. At the end of February 2023, the directorate asked all school principals to consider which of their teachers could be kept on beyond the age of 65 (ORF Wien, 2023). Other Austrian provinces chose different routes. Salzburg wrote to all retired teachers up to the age of 67, and Vorarlberg sends information on staying on with the forms teachers use to apply for their pension (ORF, 2023). Nationally, 42 teachers were employed in provincial schools in autumn 2022 after joining at age 63 or older (Austrian Parliament, 2023).

Lower Saxony reached the same conclusion as Vienna. It contacts teachers before they retire and combines the letter with financial and administrative changes (Box 5). Quebec has also used letters. In June 2023, the minister wrote to retired teachers to ask them to return for a day or two a week, or full-time. A second letter followed in August 2025, when more than 5 000 retirees were already back in schools (Le Devoir, 2025).

Outreach can also work with teachers who left recently, when it comes with help with the procedures and with better conditions in the profession. New South Wales contacted more than 1 500 teachers who had left in the previous five years, shortly after a large pay rise (Box 6).

Box 5. Lower Saxony (Germany): A package for teachers about to retire

Lower Saxony combines three instruments aimed at teachers approaching retirement. The first is financial. A retired civil-service teacher working for the state had the pension reduced once pension and salary together exceeded 125% of the pensionable pay. In October 2022, the state parliament raised this ceiling to 150% for two years. This allowed a pensioner to teach nine to ten lessons a week on average without any reduction. In October 2024 it abolished the ceiling for teachers who have reached the statutory retirement age. Teachers who retire early remain subject to a ceiling (Niedersächsischer Landtag, 2024).

The second is information. On 1 November 2023, the Minister of Education wrote to every teacher about to retire, whether a civil servant or a salaried employee. The letter set out how to stay on. A civil servant can ask to postpone retirement by up to three years, and any teacher can be re-employed on a fixed-term contract immediately after retiring while drawing the pension. The letter went to teachers approaching retirement partly because the ministry no longer held the personnel files of those who had already retired. School principals were also asked to approach these teachers in person (Niedersächsisches Kultusministerium, 2023).

The third is administrative. A teacher who continues at the same school immediately after retiring does not need to apply through the online recruitment system or to provide a new police certificate. Contact persons in each of the four regional school authorities advise retirees and handle the procedure. The number of teachers past retirement age working on fixed-term contracts rose from 229 in 2020 to 437 in 2024 (Niedersächsischer Landtag, 2025).

According to the ministry, the first contact takes place about six months before retirement. Most returners stay at or return to the school where they last taught, usually part-time and in a specific subject such as mathematics. They rarely serve as class teachers or formal mentors. The funding for these posts must be additional, so that retirees do not take positions from young teachers. No formal evaluation has been carried out, and the state has no unique teacher identifier with which to follow individual careers.

Lessons. The financial change was one part of a package. A personal letter before retirement, contact through the principal and a simpler procedure turn the decision to stay into a small step, instead of a new job application.

Source: Niedersächsischer Landtag (2024; 2025); Niedersächsisches Kultusministerium (2023); information provided by the Lower Saxony Ministry of Education.

Box 6. New South Wales (Australia): Calling back recent leavers

From November 2023, the New South Wales Department of Education contacted more than 1 500 teachers who had left its schools in the previous five years and asked them to consider returning. Those interested were offered a simpler re-employment process and help with accreditation, approval to teach and the working-with-children check. They were then placed in casual or temporary work, with permanent posts and small-group tutoring roles also available.

By May 2024, more than 260 had expressed interest and 145 had been matched with schools. About 60% of them were returning from retirement (NSW Government, 2024a). The campaign followed the largest pay rise for the state's teachers in decades, effective from October 2023. The starting salary rose from AUD 75 791 to AUD 85 000, and administrative workload was reduced (NSW Government, 2023). Teacher vacancies in the state fell from a peak of 3 311 in 2022 to 1 294 in February 2025 (NSW Government, 2025). The contribution of returners to that fall is not known.

Lessons. Recent leavers can be identified from the employer's own records. A direct call with practical help converted about one in ten of those contacted. The call coincided with better pay and a lighter administrative load. This is consistent with the evidence in Section 2 that conditions in the profession weigh heavily on whether former teachers are willing to return.

Source: NSW Government (2023; 2024a; 2025).

Advisers and information sessions

England relies on an advisory service. Former teachers can ask for an adviser who supports them one to one with applications, interviews, refresher courses and vacancies. The Department for Education's delivery plan of February 2026 lists the service and a new step-by-step guide for returners among its measures to recruit 6 500 additional teachers (Department for Education, 2026b). The service also channelled the emergency call of December 2021, when former teachers were asked to cover absences through supply agencies, "even a day a week" (Department for Education, 2021).

Japan illustrates a different use of information (Box 7). Its open licensing system has produced a large pool of licence holders who have never taught or have long been away from schools. Boards of education now run information sessions and training to bring them into temporary and part-time posts.

Box 7. Japan: Information sessions for licence holders who are not teaching

In Japan, students at any accredited university can obtain a teaching licence with a practicum of three to four weeks. Many licence holders never teach or leave early, and they form a large pool of potential teachers. On 1 May 2025, schools were short of 3 827 teachers, against 2 065 in 2021 (MEXT, 2026). The Ministry of Education, Culture, Sports, Science and Technology (MEXT) encourages boards of education to bring licence holders into schools and funded such initiatives with JPY 500 million in 2024. In 2023, 50 of the 68 prefectural and city boards of education ran sessions or training for licence holders who were not teaching (MEXT, 2024).

Results are reported for a few boards. In Saitama, seven seminars in 2023 drew 226 participants. Of these, 122 registered for temporary or part-time posts and 53 had been appointed by April 2024. In Osaka, 69 people took part in 2022 and 19 were appointed (MEXT, 2024).

The session held by the Miyazaki Prefectural Board of Education on 15 November 2025 shows what licence holders are told. It described a teacher's day today, team-based pupil guidance, rest days from club activities and the professional development on offer. It presented the posts available without sitting the competitive recruitment examination. Temporary full-time teachers start at JPY 241 900 a month. Part-time teachers work up to 680 hours a year at JPY 2 860 an hour, and school support staff up to 800 hours a year at about JPY 1 000 an hour. The session ended with individual consultations and registration as a temporary teacher, so that the prefecture can call on licence holders when a vacancy appears (Miyazaki Prefectural Board of Education, 2025).

Lessons. Sessions built around the doubts of licence holders, such as being out of date, the workload and readiness for a permanent post, can bring a share of them into schools through flexible posts. No financial incentive is involved. Research on these initiatives in Japan is still almost non-existent.

Source: MEXT (2024; 2026); Miyazaki Prefectural Board of Education (2025), translated by M. Kikuchihara.

What the evidence shows

None of these outreach initiatives has been evaluated. In most cases the data do not link returners to the contact that prompted their return. The available figures suggest that response rates to letters sent after retirement are very low. Contact before retirement, through the principal or with help with the procedures, appears more promising.

3.4 Support and training

A third group of policies reduces the practical cost of returning, through refresher courses, supervised time in classrooms, coaching and induction. These measures respond to the uncertainty that former teachers often report about changes in curricula, assessment and classroom practice. They also respond to schools' doubts about teachers who lack recent experience. The evidence on these programmes is discouraging, and unusually rich for a field with so few evaluations.

England's Return to Teaching pilot of 2016 drew far more interest than it could convert into posts (Box 8). A follow-up programme, the Returners

Engagement Programme, ran from November 2016 until it was withdrawn in March 2018. It funded lead schools in two regions to offer returners in mathematics, physics and modern foreign languages a course of two to four weeks that included teaching practice. Support was tied to identified vacancies. Schools received GBP 1 500 for each returner they employed, and returners could claim up to GBP 600 for childcare or travel (Department for Education, 2016). This programme was not evaluated.

Sweden's National Agency for Education launched a free online course for returning teachers and preschool teachers in October 2018. It covered the changes in curricula, laws and guidelines since the education reforms of 2010 and 2011. By April 2020, 1 018 people had registered, 175 had completed at least one module and 38 had completed the whole course. Only about one-third of respondents to a follow-up survey were actually returning teachers. None of the respondents who were employed had been given working time, a mentor or a study group to take the course. The course cost SEK 17 268 per participant, against SEK 863 for a comparable online course. The agency concluded that it had not reached its target group (Skolverket, 2020).

Programmes that build re-entry into the school itself appear more promising, although none has been evaluated. In the canton of Zurich (Switzerland), teachers returning after eight years or more are entitled in their first year back to the same induction as new teachers, free of charge. This includes up to 25 hours of mentoring by a trained colleague in their own school, group supervision and subject coaching. Returners can also obtain an individual assessment of the preparation they need. The canton pays the first hour and the teacher the rest (PH Zürich, 2026). In October 2026, however, the university of teacher education was not offering counselling for returners. Victoria (Australia) pays former teachers for up to 40 days in a school before they apply for a post (Box 9).

Box 8. England (United Kingdom): Lessons from the evaluation of a return-to-teaching pilot

From January to October 2016, the Department for Education funded 60 partnerships of schools to support qualified teachers returning to secondary subjects in shortage. The support covered subject knowledge, updates on assessment and behaviour management, classroom experience and mentoring, and was free for the returner. The pilot attracted 5 729 registrations, well above its target of 3 000. Of these, 354 received support. By November 2016, 62 were teaching in a state school and 27 held a permanent post in the targeted subjects. The cost per additional returner was about GBP 37 400, close to the cost of training a new teacher. The independent evaluation judged the pilot unlikely to represent good value for money (Buchanan et al., 2018).

The evaluation identified several reasons for the low conversion. Support began in January, when few posts for the following September remained open. Many schools hesitated to give returners teaching practice, citing the need to establish their quality and the risk of disrupting lessons. Only 44% of returners felt their needs had been met. Half of the returners and schools interviewed said that returners wanted part-time work, which few schools offered. Returners named their lack of recent experience, workload, the lack of flexible posts and their own confidence as the main barriers.

Lessons. Registrations far exceeded the target, and the losses came later. Re-entry support converts best when it follows the recruitment calendar, is linked to real vacancies, includes time in front of a class and is matched by schools willing to offer part-time posts.

Source: Buchanan et al. (2018).

Box 9. Victoria (Australia): A paid placement before applying

Victoria's Teacher Re-Engagement Initiative, launched in late 2022, offers registered teachers who have been away from teaching for at least 12 months a paid placement of up to 40 days in a government school. During the placement they observe classes and school routines and are mentored by serving staff, before they apply for a post. A central team matches participants with schools by subject, experience, location and availability. At the end of the placement, the team records whether the participant has returned to teaching.

The initiative drew more than 1 100 expressions of interest and received AUD 12 million in the 2023/24 state budget (Victorian Government, 2023). It is now funded by the schools that host a returner, at AUD 330 a day to cover the participant's honorarium and administrative costs (Victorian Government, 2026). No figures have been published on the number of participants who went on to teach.

Lessons. A supervised placement answers both the returner's lack of confidence and the school's uncertainty about the returner, the two obstacles identified by the evaluation in England (Box 8). Shifting the cost to schools may limit take-up to those that can afford it.

Source: Victorian Government (2023; 2026).

What the evidence shows

No causal evaluation of refresher or re-entry support has been found. The two programmes with official reviews, in England and Sweden, reached many interested people but few actual returners. In both cases the support was detached from schools and from vacancies. The retention of returners after re-entry has not been measured in any programme.

3.5 Flexible positions

A fourth group of policies offers former teachers roles other than a full-time teaching post: relief and adjunct teaching, tutoring and mentoring. These roles match the preferences that many former teachers express. As Section 2 showed, leavers with care responsibilities and retirees often want to work part of the week. In England, half of the returners and schools interviewed reported a demand for part-time work (Buchanan et al., 2018). Flexible roles also allow systems to use experience where it is most valuable.

Pools of flexible teachers

Standing pools of former teachers are the simplest version of this instrument. Singapore has run an adjunct programme for former teachers since 2004 (Box 10). In July 2026, the Bahamas announced a reserve of former teachers, retirees and recent graduates, built on its supply-teacher platform. It is part of a drive to fill about 300 vacancies in 162 public schools on 24 islands. A task force of several government agencies checks records and accreditation so that recruits can start quickly. By September 2026, more than 100 teachers had been recruited through the drive and about 100 more were being vetted (Ministry of Education of The Bahamas, 2026; ZNS Bahamas, 2026). Rules on combining pension and salary, such as those in Ireland and Ontario, also create a pool of retired substitutes.

Box 10. Singapore: An adjunct programme for former teachers

Singapore's Ministry of Education launched an adjunct teachers programme in 2004 to attract former trained teachers back to the profession on more flexible terms. Under the current Flexi-Adjunct Teaching Scheme, former teachers register on a ministry portal for three years. Schools contact them directly for appointments of one day to ten weeks, for teaching alone or for teaching and other duties agreed with the school. They are paid by the hour, in tiers that depend on experience, and earn leave once they have accumulated 90 days of service. Former ministry teachers must have performed well in their last three years of service (Ministry of Education Singapore, 2026a). A companion programme offers former ministry teachers contracts of one to one and a half years, full-time or part-time (Ministry of Education Singapore, 2026b).

From 2022 to 2024, about 220 teachers a year joined the programme within 12 months of leaving the service. The annual resignation rate of teachers was 2.4%, or 1.7% excluding those who joined the programme (Ministry of Education Singapore, 2025a; 2025b). Pay at the highest tier is below 60% of the median pay package of a classroom teacher (Ministry of Education Singapore, 2024).

Lessons. A standing pool lets a system keep in contact with teachers at the moment they leave, before their skills and their links with schools fade. It allows those who leave for family or other reasons to keep a foot in the profession on terms they choose. Pay well below that of regular teachers keeps the programme cheap, but limits its use to occasional cover.

Source: Ministry of Education Singapore (2024; 2025a; 2025b; 2026a; 2026b).

Placements in schools that struggle to attract teachers

China's Silver-Age Lecturing Plan sends retired teachers to rural schools in the poorest counties (Box 11). It is the largest programme in this review, and the only one that places returners in schools far from where they used to work. It also gives them an explicit role in developing the school's young teachers.

Box 11. China: Retired teachers for rural schools

China's Silver-Age Lecturing Plan was launched in 2018 by the Ministries of Education and Finance. It recruits retired principals, teaching researchers and senior teachers, generally aged 65 or under, to serve for at least a school year in rural primary and lower-secondary schools. The schools are in poor, ethnic-minority and border counties. Returning to one's own former school does not count. Participants teach classes, observe lessons and give demonstration lessons, coach the school's young teachers and help with school management. Since 2024, retired principals may serve as deputy heads. Participants keep their pension and receive CNY 20 000 a year for living costs, travel and insurance. The central government pays in western provinces, central and provincial governments share the cost in central provinces, and eastern provinces pay alone (Ministry of Education and Ministry of Finance of the People's Republic of China, 2018).

The first plan set a target of 10 000 places for 2018-2020. More than 20 000 retired teachers had been recruited to primary and secondary schools by mid-2023 (Ministry of Education of the People's Republic of China, 2023). Recent annual rounds have planned 6 000 to 7 000 places. The 2026 round makes the coaching of young teachers central to the role and adds an assessment by the host school at the end of each placement (Ministry of Education of the People's Republic of China, 2026). No independent evaluation has been published.

Lessons. The plan uses retired teachers above all to transfer experience to schools that struggle to attract and develop teachers. This is the use of former teachers that the evidence on mentoring and peer learning supports (Section 2).

Source: Ministry of Education and Ministry of Finance of the People's Republic of China (2018); Ministry of Education of the People's Republic of China (2023; 2026).

Mentors and tutors

Mentoring and tutoring by retired teachers have been tested more rigorously than any other instrument in this review (Box 12). Three randomised trials in the United States found positive effects on pupils' learning. The effects were small for the mentoring of new teachers, and larger for the tutoring of pupils who were falling behind. These results are consistent with the broader experimental evidence on tutoring cited in Section 1 (Nickow, Oreopoulos and Quan, 2024). They suggest that tutoring is one of the most productive uses of former teachers who do not wish to return to a full post.

Smaller initiatives point in the same direction. At the University of Zaragoza (Spain), ten retired early-childhood and primary teachers mentored 57 student teachers in the final years of their degree in 2018. Each group met three times, on the profession, on further training and on the teaching career. Of the students who responded to a survey, 56% said the sessions had helped them to choose their path (Lizalde Gil and Cortés Pascual, 2019).

Box 12. United States: Evidence from three randomised trials on retired teachers as mentors and tutors

Mentoring new teachers. In Aurora, Colorado, recently retired teachers and principals mentored teachers in their first three years in 11 high-poverty elementary schools, in 2013/14 and 2014/15. Mentors were paid USD 41 an hour and met each new teacher for about an hour a week over two years. A randomised trial of 77 teachers compared them with the district's usual support, a colleague paid a small stipend. Pupils of mentored teachers gained 0.064 standard deviations in mathematics after the first year, about one month of learning. The effect was of similar size after the second year, but was no longer statistically significant. There was no effect on reading or on whether the new teachers stayed (DeCesare et al., 2017).

Tutoring in mathematics. In 76 schools in four urban districts, first graders with weak number skills received about 30 hours of small-group tutoring over 17 weeks. Most of the 86 tutors were retired or substitute teachers, hired through a temporary staffing company and trained for one day plus two short follow-up sessions. In a randomised trial of 994 pupils, tutored pupils outperformed their peers by an effect size of 0.34 (Gersten et al., 2015).

Tutoring in reading. AARP Foundation Experience Corps trains volunteers aged 50 and over, among them former teachers, to tutor children so that they read well by the end of grade 3. In 2023/24, 1 284 volunteers worked with 3 659 children in 18 communities (AARP Foundation, 2026). A randomised evaluation in 23 schools in Boston, New York City and Port Arthur found gains in reading comprehension, with effect sizes of 0.13 to 0.17 for pupils who attended 35 sessions or more (Morrow-Howell et al., 2009).

Lessons. Short training is enough for experienced teachers to tutor effectively. The returns on mentoring new teachers are smaller and depend on the time mentors can spend with them.

Source: DeCesare et al. (2017); Gersten et al. (2015); Morrow-Howell et al. (2009); AARP Foundation (2026).

3.6 Flexible re-certification

A final group of policies lowers the regulatory barriers to returning. Section 2 showed that licensing rules rarely drive qualified teachers out of the profession, but can stand in the way of their return. A teacher who has been away for several years may need to renew a lapsed licence or complete a refresher programme before teaching again. That process can take months and cost money, at the moment when a school is waiting to fill a post.

New Zealand has gone furthest. It replaced its refresher course with a plan agreed with the school that offers the returner a job (Box 13). In the United States, Virginia's Executive Directive 3 of September 2022 instructed the state's licensing authority to issue licences to retired teachers whose licences had lapsed. In November 2023, the state launched an online licensing system (Commonwealth of Virginia, 2022). Other policies include lighter forms of the same instrument. New South Wales helped returners with accreditation (Box 6), and Lower Saxony waives a new police certificate for teachers who continue at their school after retiring (Box 5). In the Bahamas, a government task force checks records and accreditation so that recruits can start without delay.

Box 13. New Zealand: From a refresher course to a plan agreed with the school

To renew a practising certificate, a New Zealand teacher must have at least two years of satisfactory teaching in the previous five. Teachers who did not meet this requirement used to complete an external refresher programme, the Teacher Education Refresh. Since September 2024, the Teaching Council has allowed returners with a job offer to replace it with a return-to-practice plan. In December 2025, the Council made this route permanent from January 2026 under the name Kia Maia, and extended it to some teachers who would otherwise need the refresher programme (Teaching Council of Aotearoa New Zealand, 2025).

The returner assesses, with the principal of the school that has offered the job, what has changed since they last taught. The plan lists at least three resources for each professional standard that the returner will use during the first 12 months back. Both sign the plan. Council staff review it without assessing the teacher's competence, and the certificate is renewed. Without a job offer, the refresher programme is still likely to be required (Teaching Council of Aotearoa New Zealand, 2026).

The government also paid the registration fees of returning teachers from October 2024, supporting 352 returners by April 2025. It has covered the fees of all teachers since July 2025, with NZD 53.3 million over three years (Ministry of Education New Zealand, 2025). From January to October 2026, 501 teachers renewed their certificate through Kia Maia. Most worked in primary (198) or secondary (133) schools or in early childhood education (110). Women made up 84% of users, and 62% were aged 31 to 50. Only 16% were aged 61 or over (Teaching Council of Aotearoa New Zealand, unpublished). The pathway thus mainly brings back mid-career teachers who had stepped away.

Lessons. Replacing an external course with a plan agreed with the employing school removes a cost and a delay at the moment the returner has a job in hand. It also involves the principal in the returner's first year, which the evidence on induction and leadership in Section 2 suggests matters for whether returners stay.

Source: Teaching Council of Aotearoa New Zealand (2025; 2026; unpublished); Ministry of Education New Zealand (2025).

No evaluation of these changes is available. New Zealand's data show who uses the new route, but not whether its users would have returned through the refresher programme. Collecting comparable data before and after the change would allow the effect of the reform to be measured.

3.7 Lessons for the design of re-entry policies

Five lessons emerge from the 30 policies reviewed. They should be read with caution, since few policies have been evaluated.

First, instruments work best in combination. Lower Saxony paired the removal of a financial penalty with a personal letter and a simpler procedure. New South Wales called back recent leavers after a large pay rise and a cut in administrative work. New Zealand tied re-certification to a job offer and to the school's principal. In contrast, the programmes that offered support or money alone, without suitable posts or schools willing to take returners, converted little of the interest they raised.

Second, timing matters. Contact before retirement or at the moment of leaving reaches teachers while their skills and links with schools are intact. Lower Saxony writes to teachers about to retire, and Singapore engages teachers within a year of their resignation. Support offered after posts have been filled, as in the English pilot, is largely wasted.

Third, the role offered to returners should match their preferences and their experience. Many returners want part-time work, and the strongest evidence of benefits for pupils concerns retired teachers as tutors and mentors. Policies that only offer a full-time post in a hard-to-staff school risk sending returners back to the conditions that led them to leave (Section 2).

Fourth, conditions decide take-up. Waiting periods, limits on the date of retirement and narrow eligibility rules determined the reach of the pension policies reviewed, as the cases of Georgia, Portugal and Virginia show. Designs that pay contributions without new pension rights can widen access while containing costs and avoiding incentives to retire early.

Fifth, systems need data to learn from these policies. Few systems can link returners to the policy that brought them back or follow how long they stay. A unique teacher identifier, records of who was contacted and how, and evaluations built into new policies from the start would allow governments to know which instruments work. Re-entry policies remain a complement to retention. The evidence in Section 2 suggests that the conditions that keep teachers in the profession are the same as those that bring them back.

4. Conclusions

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